MODULE 11

CASE STUDY

The Weight of Building

Three founders. Three breaking points. One question: what would you have done differently?

Prepare this case before class. Come ready to take a position.

THE SITUATION

Composite Case, 2025

This module examines three founder scenarios drawn from common patterns:

Founder A: A technical founder working 80+ hours/week. Their co-founder just quit. Revenue is growing but they feel like they're drowning.

Founder B: A CEO who hit €1M ARR but feels empty, anxious, and can't sleep. Success hasn't brought the satisfaction they expected.

Founder C: A student entrepreneur whose startup is failing publicly in a course like this one. They're embarrassed and considering dropping out.

KEY FACTS

- 72% say building affected their mental health (Startup Snapshot 2023)
- Lifetime depression: 30% vs ~15% comparison (Freeman et al. 2015)
- 49% report ≥1 lifetime mental-health condition (Freeman et al. 2015)
- Identity fusion: 'I am my startup'
- Isolation and identity fusion are the recurring risk patterns
- Energy management > time management

THE DECISION

For each founder: What are the warning signs? What should they do?

OPTION A

Founder A should hire immediately — delegate before they burn out completely

OPTION B

Founder B should take a 2-week break — reconnect with purpose outside the company

OPTION C

Founder C should reframe failure — killing a bad idea IS the learning, not a loss

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Come prepared to defend your position with evidence from the case.

1. For each founder, what are the early warning signs that should have triggered action earlier?
1. Apply the Four Dimensions of Energy framework: where is each founder depleted?
1. What's a 'wellbeing protocol' and how would you design one for yourself?
1. Why is founder mental health a strategic issue, not just a personal one?